

Reading Visual Culture

What have people learned to notice, trust and act on, before they ever read a product?



4 TOOLS

ABOUT A WEEK, 3 SESSIONS

PARTICIPANT-LED • IMAGE-FIRST

What is this component?

Designers usually start with an imagined user and read everything through them. This component flips the order. **The participant shows what the situation actually looks like, in their own world, before the designer explains it.**

The participant decides what matters in the picture.

Visual culture is not how things look. It's what people have learned to recognise, trust, ignore and act on.

NOT A PERSONA...

A persona asks **who**.

...A CONTEXT SCENARIO

Asks who, **where, when, under what conditions, with what information and whose help**.

EVERY CLAIM CARRIES AN EVIDENCE STATUS

OBSERVED

Visible in the image or the moment.

REPORTED

The participant said it.

INFERRED

Our reading of the evidence.

HYPOTHESISED

A possibility we still need to check.

One photo is a situation. Repeated photos are a pattern. A pattern the participants also describe is a stronger claim. **Never make a cultural claim from a single image.**

THE ROUTE



You need: 3–6 participants with camera phones, consent to use their photos, a printer, a big table or wall.

Show

What does the moment actually look like, in their world?

🕒 A WEEK TO CAPTURE 30 MIN BRIEF · 45 MIN TALK-BACK EFFORT ●●○ PARTICIPANTS' PHONES

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

Where people really learn, check, convert and get help, seen through their own camera.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

Every photo has the three answers written beside it, in the participant's own words.

WHAT IS IT?

Give participants six photo missions. They photograph their own world for a week. Then you sit with them and ask the same three questions about every photo, so you never have to guess what an image means.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Mission	One photo brief, like "Show me what you keep beside you."
Three questions	What is this? Why did you show us this? What were you doing?
Capture rule	Never show example photos first. Examples steer what people shoot.
Own words	Answers can be written in any language or script.

YOU NEED

Participants with camera phones, the mission cards (p.2.05), consent for their photos

YOU'LL END UP WITH

A wall of captioned photos, each tagged Observed or Reported, for Tool 2

NEXT PAGE **Example • Meera's photos** →

Meera's photos, one per mission

EXAMPLE

M01 <i>Screenshot of a class WhatsApp group: a forwarded notice with the last date circled.</i> Where you learn WHAT IS THIS? Class group message. WHY SHOW US? This is where I found out. Not the website. DOING? Checking the last date again. REPORTED	M02 <i>A notebook page with user ID, password and application number in pen, next to her phone.</i> What you keep beside you WHAT IS THIS? My notebook. WHY SHOW US? I write the IDs here. The SMS gets deleted. DOING? Logging in. OBSERVED	M03 <i>The cybercafé counter. The owner's hand on the mouse, her certificate on the scanner.</i> Who or what helps WHAT IS THIS? Bhaiya ki dukaan. WHY SHOW US? "Unko setting pata hai" (he knows the setting). DOING? Making the file small. REPORTED
M04 <i>Three steps in one frame: paper certificate, its phone photo, the PDF on the café screen.</i> When information changes WHAT IS THIS? My certificate becoming a PDF. WHY SHOW US? It changes three times before it's accepted. DOING? Converting. OBSERVED	M05 <i>Her father's phone on a shelf at home, with a paper slip that says "OTP" in her writing.</i> When the expected way fails WHAT IS THIS? Papa's phone. WHY SHOW US? The OTP goes here, not to me. DOING? Waiting for him to call back. REPORTED	M06 <i>The portal page. Her finger on the small red "Pending" next to the government emblem.</i> What you know to look at WHAT IS THIS? The emblem and the status. WHY SHOW US? If it has the emblem, it's real. Red means something's wrong. DOING? Checking if it's fake. REPORTED

TO COMPONENT 3 "Setting" came up in her own words. Log it for thick translation in Reading Language, Tool 2.

Illustrative example. Photos are described, not shown. Use your participants' real photos, with consent.

How to use it

Next page · Blank template →

1

Hand out the six missions. Show no example photos.

2

Give them a week. Any number of photos per mission.

3

Talk-back: ask the three questions about every photo.

4

Write their answers in their words, any language.

5

Tag each answer Observed or Reported. Print photos small.

Mission cards + photo slips

BLANK TEMPLATE

Print on card. Cut out. Give one set to each participant. Print a photo slip for every photo at the talk-back.

MISSION 01 C2 · SHOW Show me where you learn Something that helps you know what to do: a message, notice, document, person, screenshot, note, or something else. → What did this help you understand?	MISSION 02 C2 · SHOW Show me what you keep beside you Not the task. What is around it: anything you keep close to complete, understand or check it. → Why do you need this?	MISSION 03 C2 · SHOW Show me who or what helps Whatever helps when something becomes unclear or difficult: a person, message, screen, object, place or route. → What would you have done without it?
MISSION 04 C2 · SHOW Show me when information changes Follow information as it changes form: one format, language, screen or document becoming another. → What changed before you could use it?	MISSION 05 C2 · SHOW Show me when the expected way doesn't work Don't just show the problem. Show what you did instead: another person, device, place or attempt. → What made you do this instead?	MISSION 06 C2 · SHOW Show me what you know to look at Something you look for before deciding what to do, what to trust or what to ignore. → How did you learn that this mattered?
PHOTO NO. ___ · M__ ANSWER IN ANY LANGUAGE OR SCRIPT What is this? _____ Why did you show us this? _____ What were you doing? _____ TAG OBSERVED REPORTED		PHOTO NO. ___ · M__ ANSWER IN ANY LANGUAGE OR SCRIPT What is this? _____ Why did you show us this? _____ What were you doing? _____ TAG OBSERVED REPORTED

NEXT **Tool 2 · Read** →

Read

What keeps happening, and what makes it possible?

⌚ 60-90 MIN TEAM OF 2-4 EFFORT ●●● A BIG TABLE OR WALL

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

Patterns across everyone's photos, what each pattern depends on, and where the product shows it differently.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

Every cluster has been through all three passes, and every claim has an evidence status.

WHAT IS IT?

Lay every photo on the table. Sort them three times, each time asking a different question. Group first, name second. Then test each cluster against nine structures, as questions, never as boxes to sort into.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Pass 1	What is happening? Same action or moment.
Pass 2	What is making it possible? Ignore the action.
Pass 3	What does the product show differently?
Structure	A question to test a cluster: social, material, linguistic...
Stop rule	A question that only gives an assumption is marked Hypothesised.

YOU NEED

All the captioned photos from Tool 1, sticky notes in three colours, the product open

YOU'LL END UP WITH

Named clusters, what enables them, and the gaps, for Tool 3

NEXT PAGE **Example · Three passes** →

Three passes over the photos

EXAMPLE

PASS 1 · WHAT IS HAPPENING?

Checking 0 M1 M6 P2-4	Converting 0 M3 M4 P3-2	Waiting 0 M5 P4-1	Keeping records 0 M2 P2-6
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PASS 2 · WHAT MAKES IT POSSIBLE?

Checking A class WhatsApp group · a senior · the emblem R

Converting A cybercafé · ₹30–50 · the owner's know-how R

Waiting Father's phone · father's free time R

Keeping records A paper notebook · a pen 0

PASS 3 · WHAT DOES THE PRODUCT SHOW DIFFERENTLY?

PRODUCT SHOWS "Upload your documents (PDF, max 200KB)." 	PHOTOS SHOW A paper certificate, photographed, carried to a café, converted by someone else. 	WHAT CHANGED Format, place and person. Three steps the product calls one. I
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STRUCTURES TESTED · SHADED ONES HELD UP FOR THIS CLUSTER

Social Who else must be involved?	Institutional Who has permission to resolve this?	Knowledge What had to be known already?	Material What physical thing had to exist?	Economic Did making this work cost anything?
Linguistic Did meaning change as information moved?	Authority What makes one version trustworthy?	Risk What happens if they get it wrong?	Adaptation What did they change to make it work?	

Illustrative example. P2–P4 are other participants.

How to use it

Next page · Blank template →

1

Lay every photo out. Group by action only.

2

Regroup: what is present that makes it possible?

3

Put the product's version next to each cluster.

4

Ask the nine structures as questions.

5

Tag every claim. Unsupported ones become Hypothesised.

Three passes

BLANK TEMPLATE

PASS 1

What is happening?

Group photos by the same action or moment. Ignore who is in them.

PASS 2

What makes it possible?

Person, document, device, place, knowledge, connection, money, time, authority, routine.

PASS 3

Product shows → photos show

What is missing, simplified or changed between them?

STRUCTURES TO TEST, AS QUESTIONS

Social

Who else must be involved?

Institutional

Who has permission to resolve this?

Knowledge

What had to be known already?

Material

What physical thing had to exist?

Economic

Did making this work cost anything?

Linguistic

Did meaning change as information moved?

Authority

What makes one version trustworthy?

Risk

What happens if they get it wrong?

Adaptation

What did they change to make it work?

STOP

If a question only produces an assumption, mark it **HYPOTHESISED**. Don't put it in the scenario until the evidence supports it.

 NEXT **Tool 3 • Build** →

Build

What situation are we actually designing for?

🕒 45 MIN PAIR OR TEAM EFFORT ●●○ DESK

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

One real situation: the moment, what the person sees, where information comes from, who helps, and what breaks.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

All nine boxes are filled from evidence, or honestly left as “unknown”.

WHAT IS IT?

Turn the clusters into a Context Scenario. Nine boxes, each answered only from the photos, the talk-backs and repeated patterns. Paste photos straight onto the sheet.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Context Scenario	A situation, not a persona. Who, where, when, what conditions.
Condition	The combination that keeps appearing: timing + a person + a thing.
Hidden work	What happens outside the product that nobody designed.
Edge-case check	"This was treated as ____, but the evidence shows ____."

YOU NEED

Your clusters from Tool 2, 3–5 printed photos, glue

YOU'LL END UP WITH

One Context Scenario to design against, for Tool 4

NEXT PAGE **Example • Meera's scenario** →

A Context Scenario

EXAMPLE

01 • THE MOMENT

R

What is actually happening?

Exam week, 9 pm. Uploading the income certificate two days before the deadline.

02 • THE WORLD AROUND THEM

O

What do they see?

A class WhatsApp thread, a notebook of IDs, a phone at 12%. The portal comes last.

03 • INFORMATION JOURNEY

R

Where does it come from?

Notice → class group → senior → Meera → café owner → portal.

04 • THE VISUAL CUE

R

What tells them what to trust?

The government emblem. Red text means "something is wrong".

05 • PEOPLE AROUND THEM

R

Who else is involved?

A senior (explains), the café owner (converts), her father (holds the OTP).

06 • WHAT THEY ALREADY KNOW

I

What does it assume?

What a PDF is, which number is registered, that "pending" can mean weeks.

07 • THE HIDDEN WORK

O

What happens off-screen?

Photographing, travelling, paying ₹30–50, waiting for a call back.

08 • THE CONDITION

I

What combination keeps appearing?

Deadline pressure + a paper document + a helper with a device + someone else's phone.

09 • THE CONSEQUENCE

R

What breaks if one condition goes?

No café open at night → no PDF → misses the deadline. Seen in 2 of 4 participants.

EDGE-CASE CHECK

This was treated as **"a student with a slow internet connection"**, but the evidence shows **an upload that needs three places and two other people**.

THE VISUAL READING

She has learned to trust the emblem and the class group, and to distrust anything red, before she reads a single word.

Illustrative example.

How to use it

Next page • Blank template →

1

Answer box 01 first. Be specific about time and pressure.

2

Paste 3–5 photos into box 02.

3

Draw the information journey as arrows.

4

Tag every box. Leave unknowns as "unknown".

5

Write the edge-case check and the visual reading.

Context Scenario

BLANK TEMPLATE

01 • THE MOMENT

What is actually happening?

02 • THE WORLD AROUND THEM

What do they see?

03 • INFORMATION JOURNEY

Where does it come from?

04 • THE VISUAL CUE

What tells them what to trust?

05 • PEOPLE AROUND THEM

Who else is involved?

06 • WHAT THEY ALREADY KNOW

What does it assume?

07 • THE HIDDEN WORK

What happens off-screen?

08 • THE CONDITION

What combination keeps appearing?

09 • THE CONSEQUENCE

What breaks if one condition goes?

EDGE-CASE CHECK

This was treated as _____, but the evidence shows

_____.

THE VISUAL READING • WHAT HAVE THEY LEARNED TO NOTICE, TRUST, IGNORE OR ACT ON, AND WHEN?

NEXT **Tool 4 • Hand off** →

Hand off

What does this tell us about the system, not the person?

🕒 30 MIN PAIR OR TEAM EFFORT ●●○ DESK

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

What the person does in this situation, what the system has failed to make visible, and which component to take it to next.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

You have one traceable sentence where every blank points to a photo or a quote.

WHAT IS IT?

Fill a Context Profile: short verbs for what the person does in this situation. Then turn each observation about the person into a question about the system. Finish with one traceable statement and hand it off.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Context Profile	Trying to, depends on, checks, converts, works around...
Don't conclude	A claim about the person: "students depend on seniors."
Ask instead	A question about the system: "what does the senior know that the system hides?"
Hand off	Where the reading goes next.

YOU NEED

Your Context Scenario from Tool 3

YOU'LL END UP WITH

One traceable statement, handed to Component 1, 3 or 4

NEXT PAGE **Example • Meera's profile →**

Context Profile + the reading

EXAMPLE

When Meera is uploading documents at night, before a deadline...

TRYING TO
submit before the
deadline

DEPENDS ON
a café, a senior, Papa's
phone

ALREADY KNOWS
the emblem means
official

DOESN'T KNOW YET
how to make a PDF

ASKS
her senior, before
submitting

CONVERTS
paper → photo → PDF

CHECKS
the class group for
dates

WORKS AROUND
the OTP by calling home

RISKS
her data with a stranger

DOES INSTEAD
a trip to the café

HAS ACCESS TO
a phone, not a scanner

ALMOST CALLED "EXTRA"
the notebook of IDs

PERSON
"I ask my senior before
submitting."

DON'T CONCLUDE
~~Students depend on seniors.~~

ASK INSTEAD
What does the senior know that
the system hasn't made visible?

THE READING · ONE TRACEABLE STATEMENT

We observed **students converting paper documents through a café in night-time, deadline conditions (M3, M4, P3-2)**. This matters because **the upload step assumes a scanner and a PDF**. The existing product currently **calls this one step**. This makes us investigate **whether the product can accept a phone photo**.

→ HANDS OFF TO
1 • Existing Products
Can the product work under this
condition?

→ HANDS OFF TO
3 • Reading Language
What does "setting" really mean
here?

→ HANDS OFF TO
4 • Material Reality
What does the café trip cost her?

How to use it

Next page · Blank template →

1

Write the
situation on top:
"When ____ is
____..."

2

Fill each verb
from evidence
only.

3

Rewrite every
person-claim as a
system question.

4

Write the reading.
Cite a photo or
quote per blank.

5

Pick the
component it
goes to next.

Context Profile + the reading

BLANK TEMPLATE

When _____ is in this situation: _____...

TRYING TO

DEPENDS ON

ALREADY KNOWS

DOESN'T KNOW YET

ASKS

CONVERTS

CHECKS

WORKS AROUND

RISKS

DOES INSTEAD

HAS ACCESS TO

ALMOST CALLED "EXTRA"

PERSON / SITUATION

DON'T CONCLUDE

ASK INSTEAD

THE READING

We observed _____ in _____ conditions. This matters because _____. The existing product currently _____. This makes us investigate _____.

HANDS OFF TO ☐ 1 · Existing Products ☐ 3 · Language ☐ 4 · Material Reality

NEXT **Is it working?** →

Is it working?

GOOD SIGNS

- ✓ A photo surprised you: it showed a step the product doesn't know exists.
- ✓ Participants named things you would never have photographed.
- ✓ Your clusters are actions, not kinds of people.
- ✓ Every box in the scenario has a tag, and some say "unknown".

WARNING SIGNS, AND WHAT TO DO

- ✗ Every photo looks like your own guesses.
You showed examples first, or explained what a "good" photo is. Run the missions again, cold.
- ✗ A cluster is named after a group of people.
Regroup by action. "Seniors" is not a cluster; "asking before submitting" is.
- ✗ A scenario box has no photo or quote behind it.
Mark it Hypothesised, or take it back to a participant.
- ✗ Your reading describes the person, not the system.
Rewrite it as "the system hasn't made ____ visible".

What looks like an edge case from the interface may be an ordinary situation from the user's side.

Reading Language

Don't only listen to what was said.
Understand what was meant.

ऊपर वाले
की मज़ी

LITERAL: "THE ONE
ABOVE'S WISH"

MEANT: "IT'S OUT OF
MY HANDS NOW"

5 TOOLS + BEFORE YOU START

A RECORDER

A LOCAL LANGUAGE COLLABORATOR

What is this component?

In India, people rarely mean exactly what the words say. A phrase can carry a different meaning depending on the language, the tone, the region, or a gesture that goes with it. **If we only translate word for word, we lose all of that.**

Thick translation, not word-for-word.

Keep the context and the feeling along with the words. Then test the meaning with people, in both directions, before any of it reaches a screen.

THE ROUTE, AND WHERE IT LOOPS BACK



THE END PRODUCT

A glossary where every phrase has a **literal** meaning and an **implied** one. The difference between them is the useful part.

WORKS WITH COMPONENT 2

Words from photo talk-backs come here.
Drawings from the Kahavat Relay go there.

You need: consent to record, a recorder, a local language collaborator, and time to go back to people.

Understand the context first.

Do this once per place, before Tool 1. It takes a few days. Skipping it is how researchers end up translating their own assumptions.

- ☐ **Set the research question, consent and deletion rules**
What you will record, who can hear it, and when it gets deleted.
- ☐ **Spend time with a local guide and varied local people**
Before any interview. Listen to how people talk to each other.
- ☐ **Notice routines, relationships, language, communication**
Who speaks first? Which language is used for what?
- ☐ **Record possible meanings and their limits**
Write down what a phrase might mean, and what you can't know yet.
- ☐ **Write your positionality note**
Below. Your language, your background, what you might mishear.
- ☐ **Build a provisional codebook, glossary and interview guide**
Provisional means it will change after Tool 2.

POSITIONALITY NOTE

Languages I speak, and how well

Where I grew up; where they grew up

What I might hear as "normal"

Words I tend to over-read

Who will help me when I don't understand

PROVISIONAL GLOSSARY · START IT HERE, CORRECT IT IN TOOL 2

WORD OR PHRASE, AS HEARD	MIGHT MEAN	CAN'T KNOW YET

NEXT PAGE **Tool 1 • Listen** →

Listen

What did they say, and what did they mean by it?

⌚ 60–90 MIN PER PERSON RESEARCHER + NOTE-TAKER EFFORT ●●● FIELD

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

The moments where words, voice and body don't match, and what the person says those moments meant.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

Every marked moment has a Meaning Card, and the person has corrected or confirmed it.

WHAT IS IT?

Read six cue cards before the interview. During it, mark only symbols and three words. Start with daily life, not the task. When something significant happens, make a Meaning Card: what was said, what you saw, what you think. Then ask them what it meant, and write down their correction.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Cue	A signal beyond words: a pause, a switch of language, a glance.
Log	Symbols and three words only. No meaning during the interview.
Meaning Card	Said · Observed · Inferred, plus their own correction.
Probe	Hard to explain? Try a drawing or an idiom (Tool 5).

YOU NEED

Consent to record, the cue cards (p.3.05), a printed log, your provisional glossary

YOU'LL END UP WITH

Meaning Cards and key moments to transcribe, for Tool 2

NEXT PAGE **Prime • Six cue cards** →

Prime: six cue cards

READ FIRST

Read these once before the session. During it, don't interpret. Just mark what you notice with a symbol.

CARD 01

Body & posture

Opening or closing as the topic changes. Taking less space often means deference, not agreement.

→ **What makes this person comfortable, or guarded?**

CARD 02

Pause & silence

A long pause is data. Does it cluster around one topic? Silence may be deference, not confusion.

→ **Topics that make silence are often the ones design must address.**

CARD 03

Language switching

A switch mid-sentence often marks a concept that doesn't translate. Write the word exactly.

→ **Which language carries the real feeling?**

CARD 04

Social dynamics

Who else is in the room? A glance before answering is seeking approval. Someone answering for them is hierarchy.

→ **Who else has a stake? Are they in the design?**

CARD 05

Voice & tone

Faster: anxious or rehearsed. Slower: choosing words. Quieter: shame or privacy. Rising at the end: "is this right?"

→ **What do they most need, or fear, from the product?**

CARD 06

Objects & environment

Reaching for an object to explain something means the object may be the real interface.

→ **Photograph it, with consent. Take it to Component 2.**

LOG SYMBOLS

◆ Body || Pause ⇄ Switch ◎ Gaze ■ Object ↑↓ Voice ~ Deflect
 ✕ Avoided

NEXT PAGE **Example · Meera's interview** →

Log + Meaning Card

EXAMPLE

LOG EXCERPT · THREE WORDS, NO MEANING YET

SYM	WHAT	QUICK LOG	TRIGGERED BY
↔	Hindi → English	"pending" · "status"	<i>Asked about the result</i>
	6 s pause	before "Papa ka phone"	<i>Asked who gets the OTP</i>
↑↓	voice drops	"upar wale ki marzi"	<i>Asked what happens next</i>
👁	looks at roommate	then answers	<i>Asked about the café</i>

MEANING CARD · FOR THE MOMENT MARKED ⚡

SAID "Form toh bhar diya, ab upar wale ki marzi."	OBSERVED Voice drops. She looks at the floor. Laughs once, short.	INFERRED She feels she has no control over the result. Maybe also: officials, not God.
ASKED: WHAT DID THAT MOMENT MEAN TO YOU? "Not God exactly. Whoever checks it. I don't know who that is."		HER CORRECTION "Upar wale" here means an unknown official , not God. Send to Tool 2.

Illustrative example. Always record the phrase in the language it was said in.

How to use it

[Next page · Blank template →](#)

1

Start with daily life. Let them get comfortable.

2

Mark cues with a symbol and three words.

3

Pick the strongest moments. Make a Meaning Card.

4

Ask what the moment meant to them.

5

Write their correction, even if it disagrees with you.

Log + Meaning Card

BLANK TEMPLATE

PARTICIPANT CODE

DATE • PLACE

LANGUAGES IN USE

WHO ELSE IS PRESENT

SYM	CUE	QUICK LOG • ≤ 3 WORDS	TRIGGERED BY
◆	Body		
	Pause		
↔	Switch		
◎	Gaze		
■	Object		
↕	Voice		
~	Deflect		
×	Avoided		

MEANING CARD • CUT OUT, ONE PER MOMENT

SAID • IN THEIR LANGUAGE

OBSERVED

INFERRED

WHAT DID THAT MOMENT MEAN TO YOU?

THEIR CORRECTION OR DISAGREEMENT

NEXT **Tool 2 • Translate** →

Translate

What does it mean, and does it mean the same to others?

🕒 2-3 HOURS + A SURVEY WITH A LANGUAGE COLLABORATOR EFFORT ●●● DESK, THEN FIELD

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

The literal meaning, the implied meaning, and whether other people read it the same way.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

Each phrase passes the four-part support check, or goes back for another round.

WHAT IS IT?

Transcribe key moments in the original language. Translate each thickly: literal, in context, and alternatives. A local collaborator reviews it. Then test it: show people the phrase and ask what it means, in three directions. Only phrases that pass the support check move on.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Thick translation	Literal + context + alternatives, not just words.
Reverse translation	Test it back with the audience, in both directions.
Three directions	Native → English · English → native · native → regional.
Support check	Source language, who interpreted, how it was rendered, more than one source.

YOU NEED

Your recordings and Meaning Cards, a local language collaborator

YOU'LL END UP WITH

Glossary entries with literal and implied meanings, for Tool 3

NEXT PAGE **Example · “Upar wale ki marzi” →**

Thick translation + support check

EXAMPLE

AS SAID	फ़ॉर्म तो भर दिया, अब ऊपर वाले की मर्ज़ी। Form toh bhar diya, ab upar wale ki marzi.
LITERAL	"I've filled the form, now it's the wish of the one above."
IN CONTEXT	She has done her part. The outcome is decided somewhere she can't see or reach.
ALTERNATIVES	"It's in God's hands." · "It's up to the officials now." · "Nothing more I can do."
IMPLIED	Loss of control, and not knowing who decides. Resignation, with a little humour.
REVIEWED BY	Local language collaborator (Hindi, Bhojpuri). Agreed; added "the officials" reading.

REVERSE THICK TRANSLATION · SURVEY IN THREE DIRECTIONS

Native → English

Show the phrase. "What does it mean, in English?"

"It's in God's hands" · "the officials decide" [n of N]

English → native

Show "Your application is under review." "How would you say it?"

"Pending mein hai" · "upar gaya hai": *pending* is borrowed

Native → regional

Ask the collaborator for the regional version, then test it.

[Regional version from your collaborator]

SUPPORT CHECK · ALL FOUR NEEDED

✓ Source language

Hindi-English mix, recorded as such

✓ Who interpreted

Local collaborator

✓ Rendering

Conceptual gloss

✓ Single source?

No: a second reader agreed

SUPPORTED

Store the pattern. Take it to Tool 3.

Illustrative example. Replace [bracketed] parts with your survey results and your collaborator's version.

How to use it

Next page · Blank template →

1

Transcribe key moments in the original language.

2

Write literal, in context, alternatives, implied.

3

Review with a local language collaborator.

4

Survey in three directions. Note what shifts.

5

Run the support check. Missing one? Loop back.

Thick translation + support check

BLANK TEMPLATE

AS SAID
LITERAL
IN CONTEXT
ALTERNATIVES
IMPLIED
REVIEWED BY

THREE DIRECTIONS · WHAT DID PEOPLE SAY?

Native → English Show the phrase. "What does it mean, in English?"	English → native Show "Your application is under review." "How would you say it?"	Native → regional Ask the collaborator for the regional version, then test it.
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SUPPORT CHECK · TICK ALL FOUR, OR LOOP BACK

☐ Source language The actual language and any code-switching, not "English".	☐ Who interpreted None · coordinator · independent interpreter · professional.
☐ Rendering Verbatim · conceptual gloss · paraphrase.	☐ Single source? Did a second interpreter read it the same way?

☐ **Supported → Tool 3** ☐ **Not yet → translate again**

NEXT **Tool 3 · Test →**

Test

Does our wording work for this audience?

⌚ 45 MIN + TESTING

TEAM, THEN WITH PEOPLE

EFFORT ●●●

DESK, THEN FIELD

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

Whether new wording is understood, can be used through a helper, and reads as trustworthy.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

The wording passed all three lenses with the named audience, or went back for a rewrite.

WHAT IS IT?

Turn a supported meaning into a design hypothesis and a candidate wording. Check it against three lenses. Then test it with real people, in a different context from where you heard it. If it fails, rewrite, or take new questions back to Tool 1.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Hypothesis	"If we say ____, then ____ will happen."
Lens N • New	Works for someone who has never filled this exact form?
Lens P • Proxy	Still works read aloud by a CSC operator or a family member?
Lens T • Trust	Reads as official to someone primed to suspect a scam?
This audience	A named segment, never a generic user.

YOU NEED

A supported glossary entry from Tool 2, the screen you want to change

YOU'LL END UP WITH

Tested wording, ready for the Design Language Library

NEXT PAGE

Example • Rewriting "Pending" →

Candidate wording + three lenses

EXAMPLE

HYPOTHESIS

If the status names **who** is holding the application and **for how long**, students will stop reading “pending” as fate.

NOW

Status: Pending

CANDIDATE

Your college is checking your documents • day 3 of 15

आपका कॉलेज आपके दस्तावेज़ जाँच रहा है • दिन 3 / 15

THREE LENSES • THIS AUDIENCE: FIRST-GENERATION STUDENTS APPLYING ON A PHONE

N	New	Never filled this form. Knows WhatsApp and UPI, not portal words.	✓	Understood “college is checking”.
P	Proxy	Read aloud by her father over the phone.	✓	Father repeated it correctly.
T	Trust	Suspicious of anything that looks like a scam.	✗	“Call your college” link looked like a scam. Removed.

TESTED IN A DIFFERENT CONTEXT

Hostel common room, 6 students, and 2 fathers by phone. Comprehension and use.

RESULT

Round 2 passed all three lenses. Store in the Design Language Library.

Illustrative example. Check any translated UI copy with a native speaker before testing.

How to use it

Next page • Blank template →

1

Write the hypothesis in one sentence.

2

Write candidate wording, in each language.

3

Check it against lenses N, P and T.

4

Test with the named audience, somewhere new.

5

Fails? Rewrite. New questions? Back to Tool 1.

Candidate wording + three lenses

BLANK TEMPLATE

HYPOTHESIS

If we say _____, then _____ will happen.

NOW

CANDIDATE • EVERY LANGUAGE

THIS AUDIENCE _____

N	New	Works for someone who never filled this exact form?	✓ X
P	Proxy	Works read aloud by a CSC operator or a family member?	✓ X
T	Trust	Official, not scam-like? (no urgency, unofficial channel, fee)	✓ X

TESTED WHERE, WITH WHOM

RESULT • STORE, REWRITE, OR NEW QUESTIONS

NEXT **Tool 4 • Library** →

Library

How do we keep what we learned, so the next team can use it?

🕒 20 MIN PER ENTRY WHOLE TEAM EFFORT ●○○ DESK

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

A growing record of how people really speak, and which interface words have been tested with whom.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

Every supported phrase and every tested wording has an entry, with its evidence and its limits.

WHAT IS IT?

Two libraries. The Expression Library keeps supported meanings, de-identified. The Design Language Library keeps interface wording that passed testing. Together they are the start of a language system: like a design system, but for words.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Expression Library How people say things, with literal and implied meanings.

Design Language Library Tested interface wording, per language and audience.

De-identified No names, no details that point to one person.

Don't use for Where this wording or reading does not hold.

YOU NEED

Supported entries from Tool 2 and tested wording from Tool 3

YOU'LL END UP WITH

Library entries your whole team, and the next project, can reuse

NEXT PAGE **Example • Two entries →**

Two linked entries

EXAMPLE

EXPRESSION LIBRARY · EX-014		DESIGN LANGUAGE LIBRARY · DL-031	
EXPRESSION	ऊपर वाले की मर्ज़ी · upar wale ki marzi	MOMENT	Application status, after submitting
LANGUAGE	Hindi, used inside Hinglish speech	REPLACES	Status: Pending
LITERAL	The wish of the one above	ENGLISH	Your college is checking your documents · day 3 of 15
IMPLIED	Out of my hands; I don't know who decides	HINDI	आपका कॉलेज आपके दस्तावेज़ जाँच रहा है · दिन 3 / 15
HEARD WHEN	Waiting on an institution after submitting	TESTED WITH	First-gen students on phones; fathers by phone
EVIDENCE	3 participants · collaborator + second reader · supported	LENSES	N ✓ · P ✓ · T ✓ (round 2)
DON'T USE FOR	Religious meaning in every context. Ask first.	LINKED TO	EX-014 · tone: calm, specific, no urgency

Grows into a language system. Once there are enough tested entries, group them by moment (errors, waiting, success) and by voice (how formal, how warm), just like components in a design system.

Illustrative example.

How to use it

Next page · Blank entries →

1

Supported meaning? Write an Expression entry.

2

Remove names and identifying details.

3

Tested wording? Write a Design Language entry.

4

Link the two entries.

5

Say where each one does not hold.

Library entries

BLANK TEMPLATE

Print, cut out and file. Or copy the fields into a shared spreadsheet.

EXPRESSION LIBRARY · NO. ____
EXPRESSION
LANGUAGE
LITERAL
IMPLIED
HEARD WHEN
EVIDENCE
DON'T USE FOR

DESIGN LANGUAGE · NO. ____
MOMENT
REPLACES
ENGLISH
LANGUAGE 2
TESTED WITH
LENSES N·P·T
LINKED TO

EXPRESSION LIBRARY · NO. ____
EXPRESSION
LANGUAGE
LITERAL
IMPLIED
HEARD WHEN
EVIDENCE
DON'T USE FOR

DESIGN LANGUAGE · NO. ____
MOMENT
REPLACES
ENGLISH
LANGUAGE 2
TESTED WITH
LENSES N·P·T
LINKED TO

NEXT **Tool 5 · The Kahavat Relay** →

The Kahavat Relay

When words won't reach a meaning, can a drawing?

🕒 10 MIN PER PERSON 3-5 PEOPLE, ONE AFTER ANOTHER EFFORT ●○○ FIELD OR WORKSHOP

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

How a meaning travels from person to person: what survives, what shifts, and what gets added.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

The chain has at least three rounds, and you have compared the first line with the last.

WHAT IS IT?

Give the first person a kahavat (a spoken idiom). They draw what it means to them, as a moment from their own life, and write one line in their own language. The next person sees **only the drawing**. They say what is happening, write their own line, and draw their version. Keep passing it on.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Kahavat	A spoken idiom, like “ek anaar, sau beemar”.
Drawn metaphor	Their picture of the idiom, as a moment from their life.
Own-language line	One sentence, in any language or script they choose.
Chain	Each drawing becomes the prompt for the next person.

→ COMPONENT 2

Each drawing is a participant-made image. Read it in Tool 2 • Read, tagged Reported.

→ COMPONENT 3 • TOOL 2

Each own-language line gets a thick translation.

YOU NEED

Idiom cards (p.3.20), relay sheets (p.3.19), pens, consent to share drawings

YOU'LL END UP WITH

Drawings for Component 2, own-language lines for Tool 2, and new questions for Tool 1

NEXT PAGE **Example • One anaar, three people →**

One anaar, three people

EXAMPLE

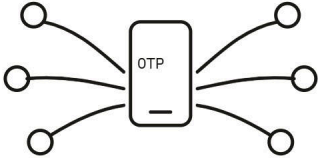
IDIOM CARD

एक अनार, सौ बीमार

Ek anaar, sau beemar · one pomegranate, a hundred sick

ROUND 1 · P1 (MEERA)

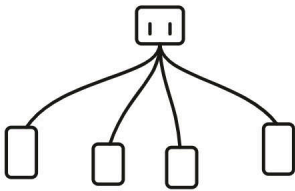
Sees the idiom card



एक ही फ़ोन है घर में, सबका OTP उसी पर आता है।
There's only one phone at home. Everyone's OTP comes to it.

ROUND 2 · P2

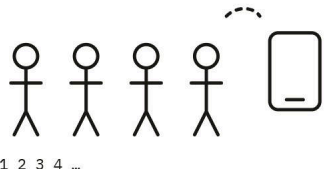
Sees only drawing 1



सब एक ही चीज़ के पीछे लगे हैं।
Everyone is after the same one thing.

ROUND 3 · P3

Sees only drawing 2



लाइन में लगे, बारी आएगी तब।
Stand in line, your turn will come.

SURVIVED

One resource, too many people.

SHIFTED

From who owns the phone → who waits for it.

ADDED

Turn-taking and time.

DESIGN QUESTION

Does the product assume one person, one phone? What happens to OTP timing when it's shared?

Illustrative example. Lines are shown in Hindi; participants write in whatever language and script they choose.

How to use it

Next page · Blank template →

1

First person gets an idiom card. Ask: when has this happened to you?

2

They draw it as their own moment, and write one line.

3

Next person sees only the drawing. What is happening?

4

They write a line and draw their own version. Repeat.

5

Compare first and last: survived, shifted, added.

Relay sheet

BLANK TEMPLATE

IDIOM CARD _____ TOPIC _____

Fold the sheet so the next person sees only the last drawing. Never show them the idiom or the earlier lines.

ROUND 1CODE ____

Sees the idiom card

DRAW HERE

ONE LINE · YOUR LANGUAGE

ROUND 2CODE ____

Sees only drawing 1

DRAW HERE

ONE LINE · YOUR LANGUAGE

ROUND 3CODE ____

Sees only drawing 2

DRAW HERE

ONE LINE · YOUR LANGUAGE

SURVIVED

SHIFTED

ADDED

DESIGN QUESTION

Drawings → Component 2 · Tool 2 (tag Reported) Lines → Tool 2 · Translate

NEXT PAGE **Idiom cards** →

Idiom cards

PRINT + CUT

Six Hindi examples, three blanks. **Better: collect idioms from the participants' own language** in Before you start, and check each meaning with your language collaborator. Don't explain the meaning to the first person unless they ask.

KAHAVAT C3 • TOOL 5 एक अनार, सौ बीमार <i>Ek anaar, sau beemar</i> LITERALLY • One pomegranate, a hundred sick USUALLY MEANS • One thing, far too many people who need it. → When has this happened to you?	KAHAVAT C3 • TOOL 5 ऊँट के मुँह में ज़ीरा <i>Oont ke munh mein jeera</i> LITERALLY • A cumin seed in a camel's mouth USUALLY MEANS • Far too little for what's needed. → When has this happened to you?	KAHAVAT C3 • TOOL 5 नाच न जाने, आँगन टेढ़ा <i>Naach na jaane, aangan tedha</i> LITERALLY • Can't dance, blames the crooked courtyard USUALLY MEANS • Blaming the surroundings for your own trouble. → When has this happened to you?
KAHAVAT C3 • TOOL 5 दूर के ढोल सुहावने <i>Door ke dhol suhaavne</i> LITERALLY • Distant drums sound sweet USUALLY MEANS • Things look better from far away. → When has this happened to you?	KAHAVAT C3 • TOOL 5 आसमान से गिरा, खजूर में अटका <i>Aasmaan se gira, khajoor mein atka</i> LITERALLY • Fell from the sky, stuck in a date palm USUALLY MEANS • Out of one trouble, straight into another. → When has this happened to you?	KAHAVAT C3 • TOOL 5 जितनी चादर, उतने पैर पसारो <i>Jitni chaadar, utne pair pasaaro</i> LITERALLY • Stretch your legs only as far as the sheet USUALLY MEANS • Live within what you have. → When has this happened to you?
KAHAVAT • FROM THE PARTICIPANTS' OWN LANGUAGE _____ _____ USUALLY MEANS _____ → When has this happened to you?	KAHAVAT • FROM THE PARTICIPANTS' OWN LANGUAGE _____ _____ USUALLY MEANS _____ → When has this happened to you?	KAHAVAT • FROM THE PARTICIPANTS' OWN LANGUAGE _____ _____ USUALLY MEANS _____ → When has this happened to you?

Is it working?

GOOD SIGNS

- ✓ A participant corrected your Meaning Card, and the correction changed your reading.
- ✓ The literal and implied meanings in your glossary are clearly different.
- ✓ A relay chain drifted, and the drift told you something the first person never said.
- ✓ Your tested wording failed a lens at least once before it passed.

WARNING SIGNS, AND WHAT TO DO

- ✗ Every phrase is written only in English.
Go back to the recording. Keep the original language and script.
- ✗ Nobody but you interpreted anything.
It is single-source. Find a language collaborator before you store it.
- ✗ “This audience” means “users”.
Name the segment: who, what device, who reads it to them.
- ✗ The relay's next person knew the idiom.
The chain is broken. Fold the sheet; show only the last drawing.

→ HANDS OFF TO

1 • Existing Products

Which screens use words people read differently?

→ HANDS OFF TO

2 • Visual Culture

Relay drawings as participant-made images.

→ HANDS OFF TO

4 • Material Reality

Who reads the screen aloud, and on whose phone?